How to install Ubuntu Server in less than 30 minutes

Jack Wallen walks you through the steps for installing one of the most user-friendly and widely-used server platforms available.

Written by **Jack Wallen,** Contributing Writer on March 14, 2023

Reviewed by **Alyson Windsor**

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For years, Ubuntu Server has been my go-to server operating system. Not only is it one of the most widely-used server OSs on the planet (especially when you add cloud deployments into the mix), it's also one of the most user-friendly server platforms available. To make Ubuntu Server even more appealing, you can download and install it on as many machines as you like for free.

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Ubuntu Server can be installed on bare metal (in other words, on a physical machine), as a virtual machine, or as a virtual environment on a third-party cloud host (such as AWS, Azure, or Google Cloud). With Ubuntu Server, there's no end to the number of applications and services (such as WordPress, Nextcloud, Invoice Plane, email servers, web servers, database servers, and much, much more).

I'm going to walk you through the installation of Ubuntu Server, a process so easy it'll surprise you. I'll be demonstrating using the VirtualBox virtual machine tool, which can be installed on Linux, macOS, and Windows. Other than the process of creating the virtual machine, the installation of Ubuntu Server is the same, regardless of how you do it.

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Let's walk through this.

Requirements

Other than having a machine to install Ubuntu Server on, you'll need to download the latest ISO image from the official Ubuntu Server download page. Once you've saved that ISO image, what you do next will depend on the type of hardware you plan on using. If you'll be installing Ubuntu Server as a virtual machine, you only need to create the virtual machine with your tool of choice (such as VirtualBox or VMware). If you'll be installing Ubuntu Server onto a physical machine, you'll need to burn that ISO image to a USB flash drive.

Also: How to install Ubuntu Linux (It's easy!)

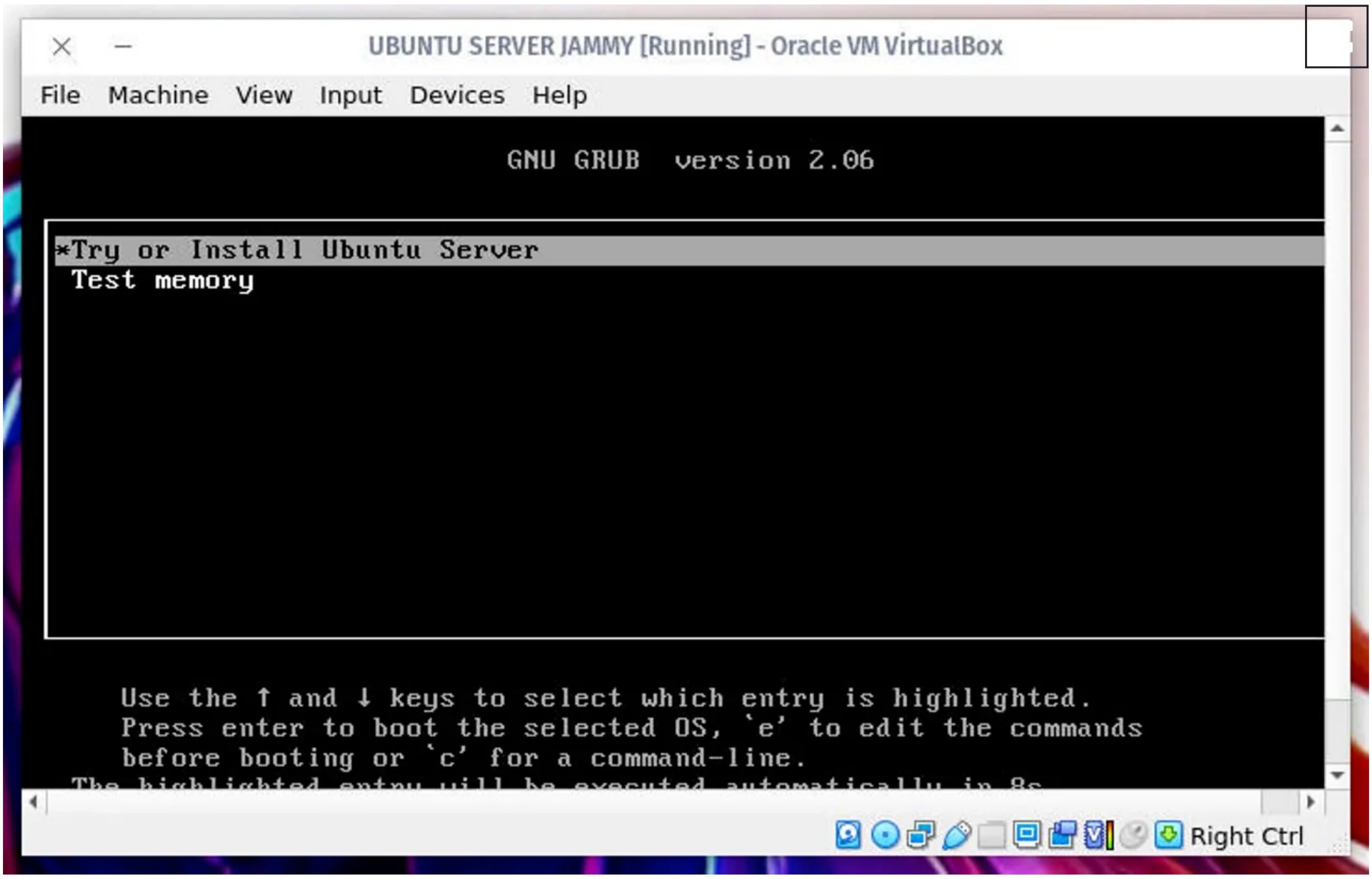
When I say "burn" the ISO image, I don't mean simply copying it. What you must do is create a bootable image using a tool like Unetbootin, Popsicle, Rufus, Windows USB/DVD Download Tool, RMPrepUSB, Yumi, UUByte ISO Burner, or Wintoflash. Each of these tools works differently, so find one for your desktop operating system of choice and you should find it fairly easy to install and create a bootable USB drive from the downloaded Ubuntu Server ISO image. You can learn how to "burn" an ISO image to create a bootable USB drive in my tutorial "How to create a bootable Linux USB drive."

And now, to the installation.

Installing Ubuntu Server

1. Configure the language and update the installer

Either start your virtual machine or insert your USB drive into your machine and boot it up. In the first window, select (using your keyboard up/down arrows) **Try or install Ubuntu Server** and hit Enter on your keyboard.

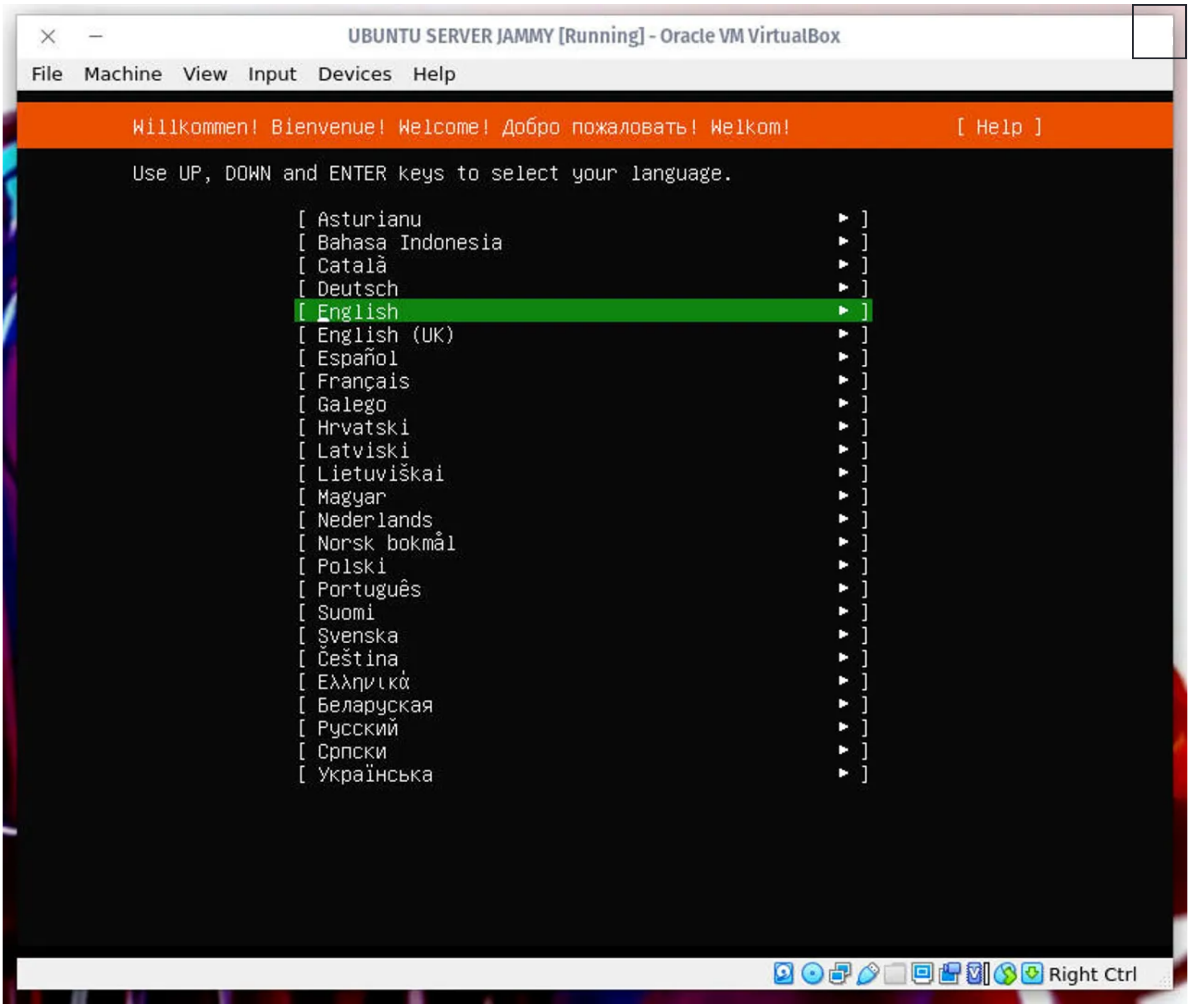


The initial installer screen for Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

Depending on the release downloaded, you might be prompted to update the installer. If so, go ahead with the update, to enjoy a simpler, more flexible installation process.

Once that's taken care of, in the next window, select the language for the installation.



Selecting a language for the installation of Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

Using your arrow keys, select your language of choice and hit Enter on your keyboard.

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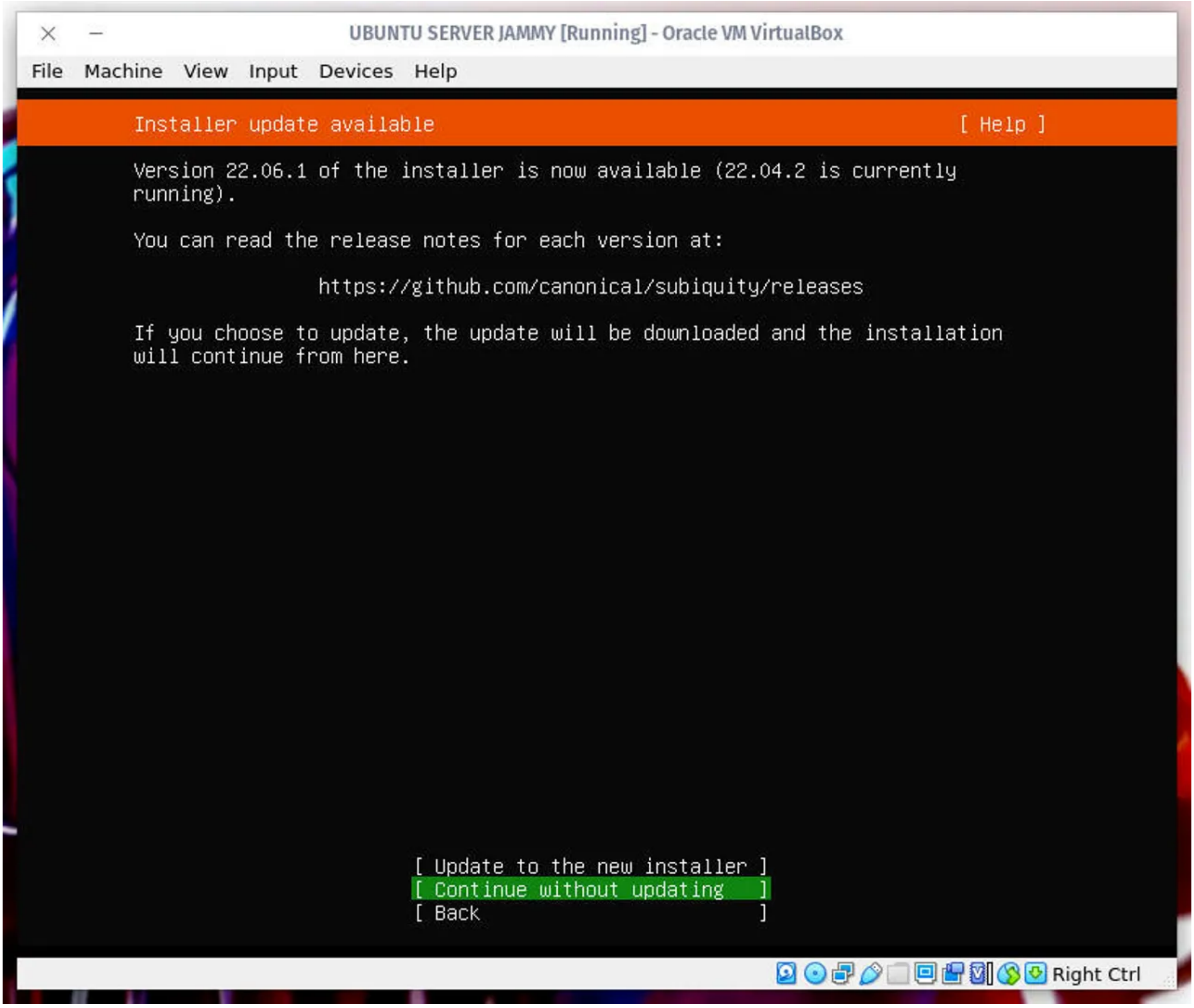
In the resulting window, use your arrow keys to select Update to the new installer and hit Enter on your keyboard.

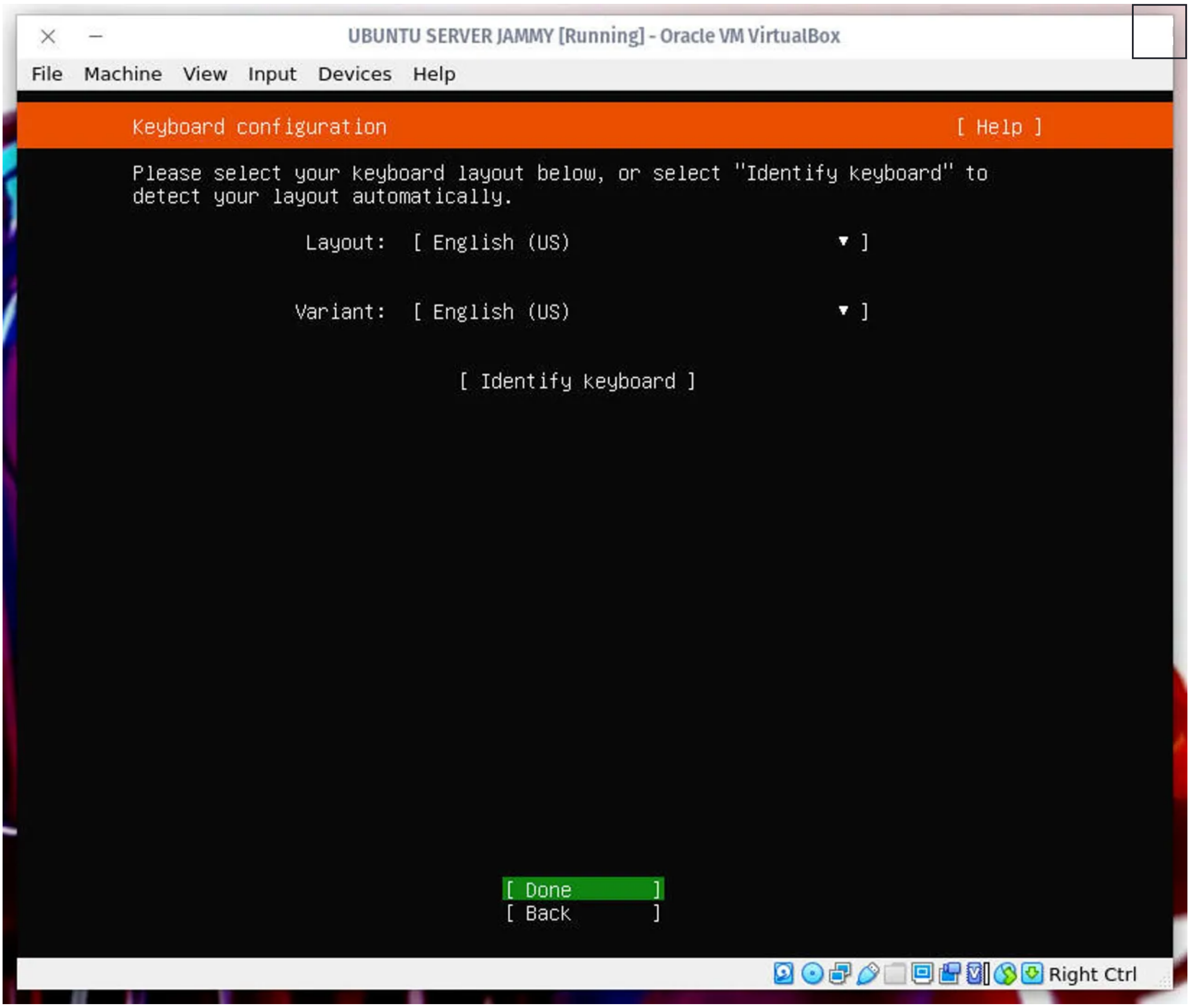


Updating the installer.

Image: Jack Wallen

2. Configure your keyboard

On the next screen, you are asked to configure your keyboard. Select both the layout and the variant.



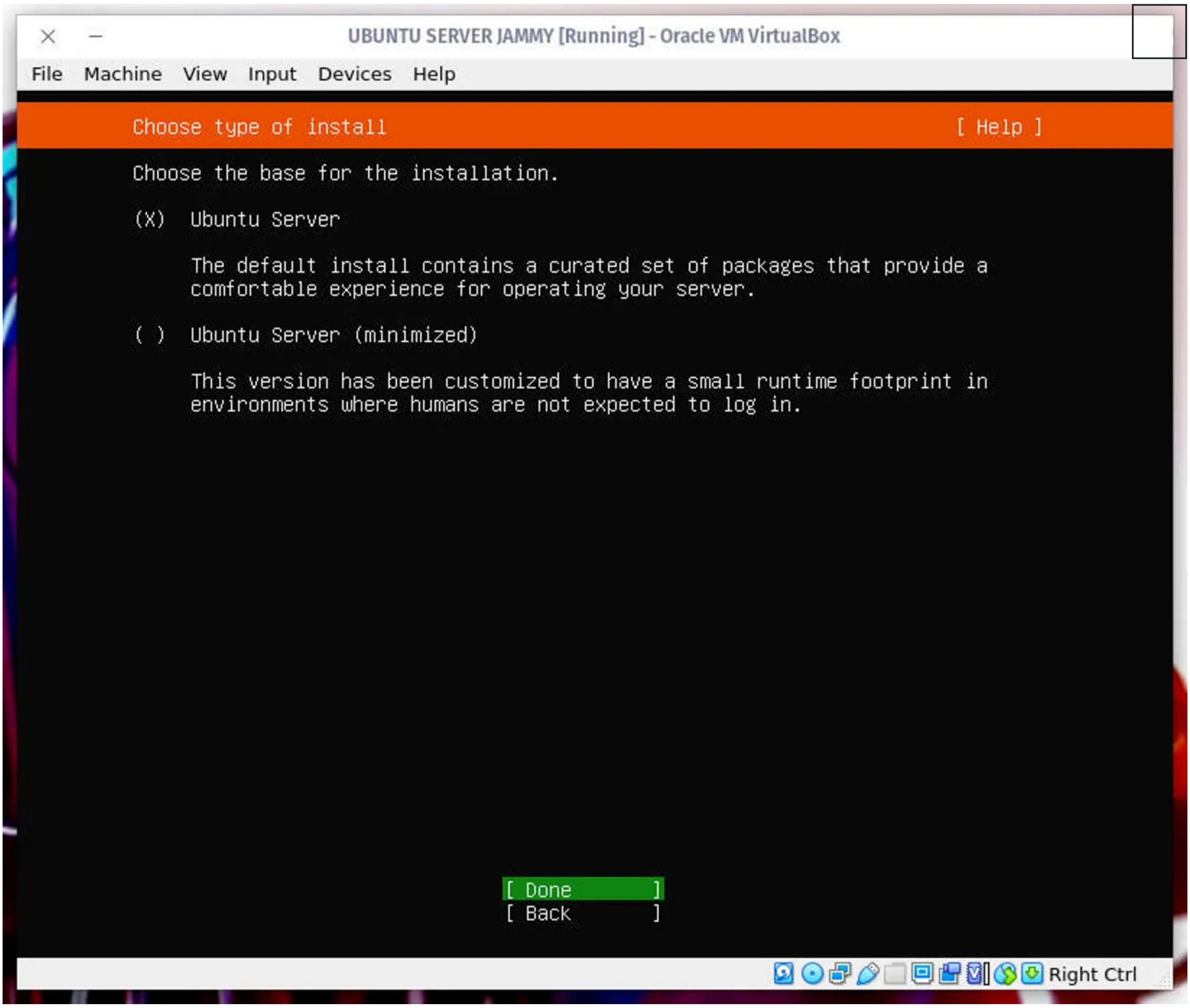
Setting the keyboard layout and variant for Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

When you're done, select **Done** (using your arrow keys) and hit Enter on your keyboard.

3. Choose the type of installation

Next, we'll select the base for the installation. Here you'll want to select Ubuntu Server (to get the most tools installed by default) and continue.

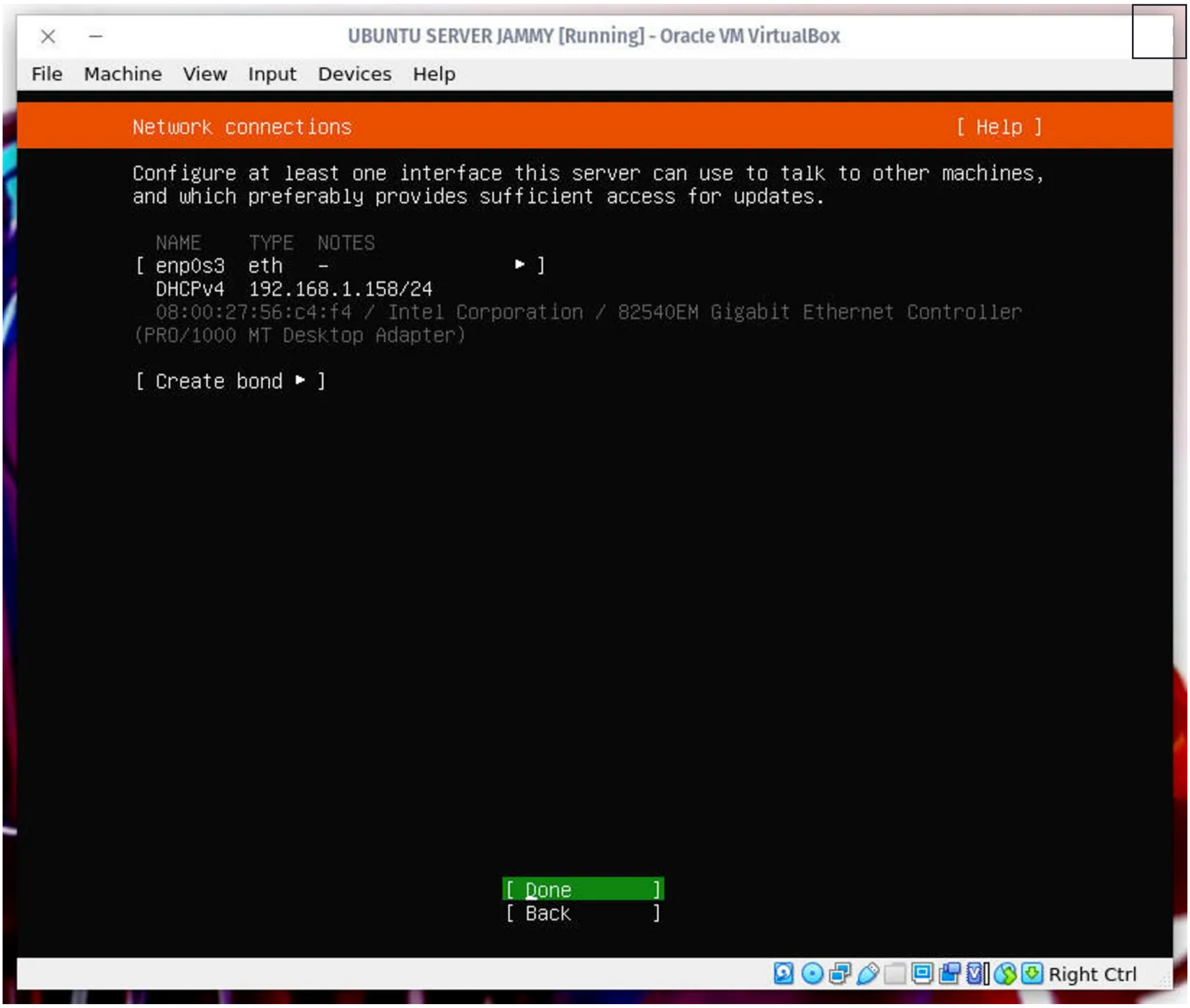


Selecting the base installation for Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

4. Configure the network

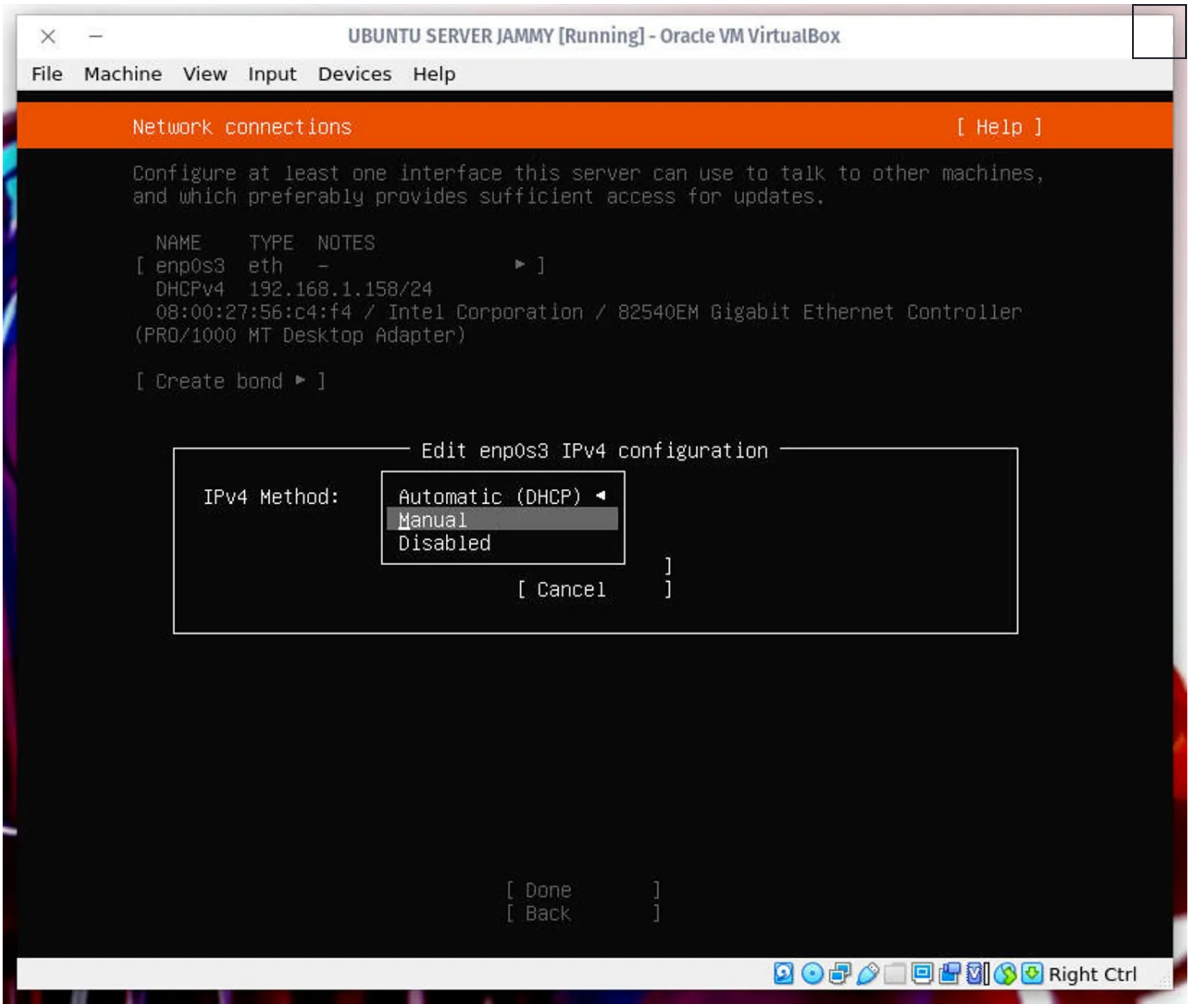
Now you have two choices. You can either go with the default DHCP or configure a static IP address. I prefer configuring static IP addresses, as it ensures the server will always be reachable by a specific IP address.



Choosing the type of network configuration for Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

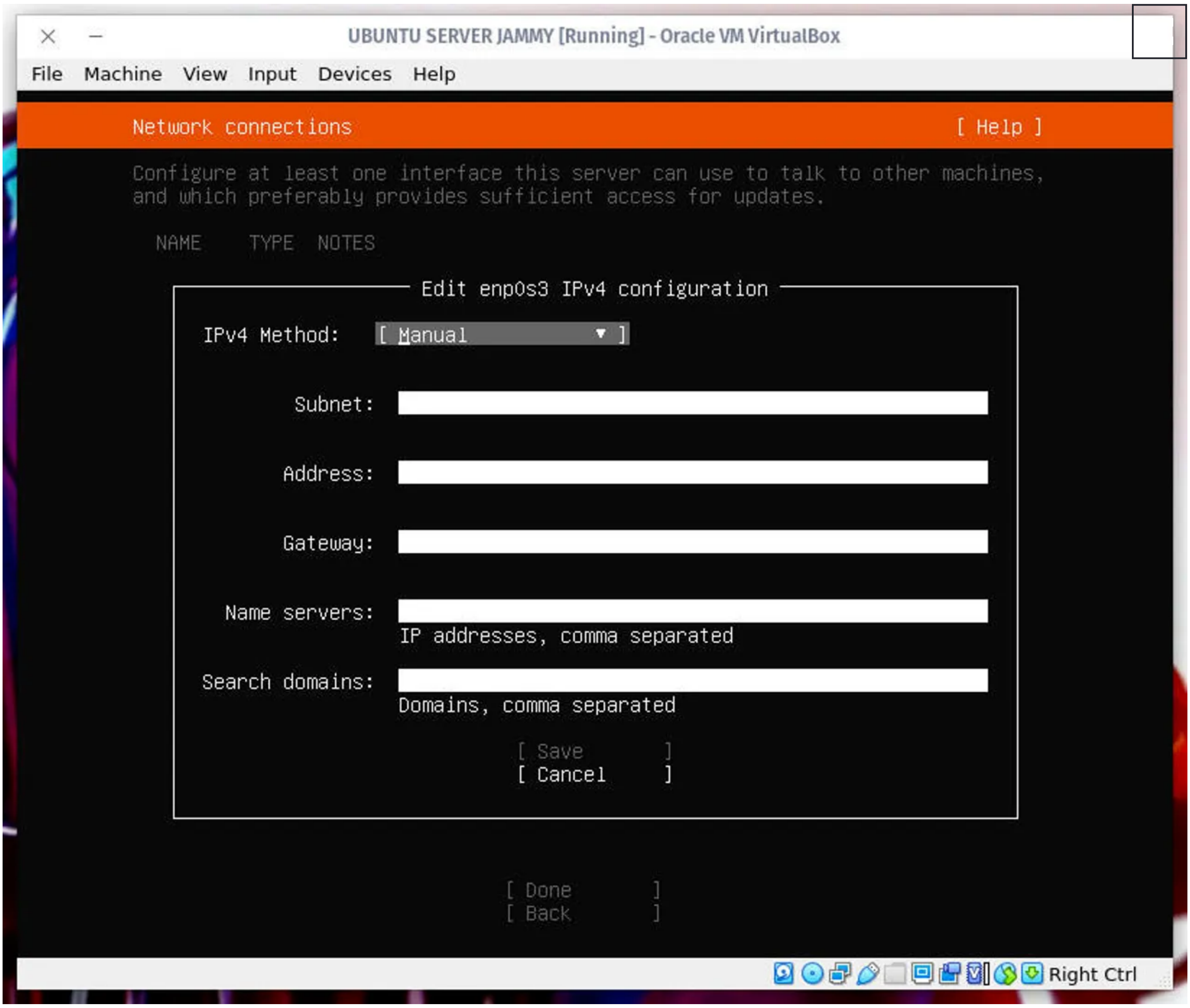
To set a static IP address, use your arrow keys to select the network connection (in my case it's enp0s3) and hit Enter on your keyboard. In the resulting popup, select **Edit IPv4** and then hit Enter to switch from Automatic to Manual.



Configuring a static IP address for Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

In the resulting window, configure the static network address according to your needs.



Editing enp0s3 as a static IP address.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

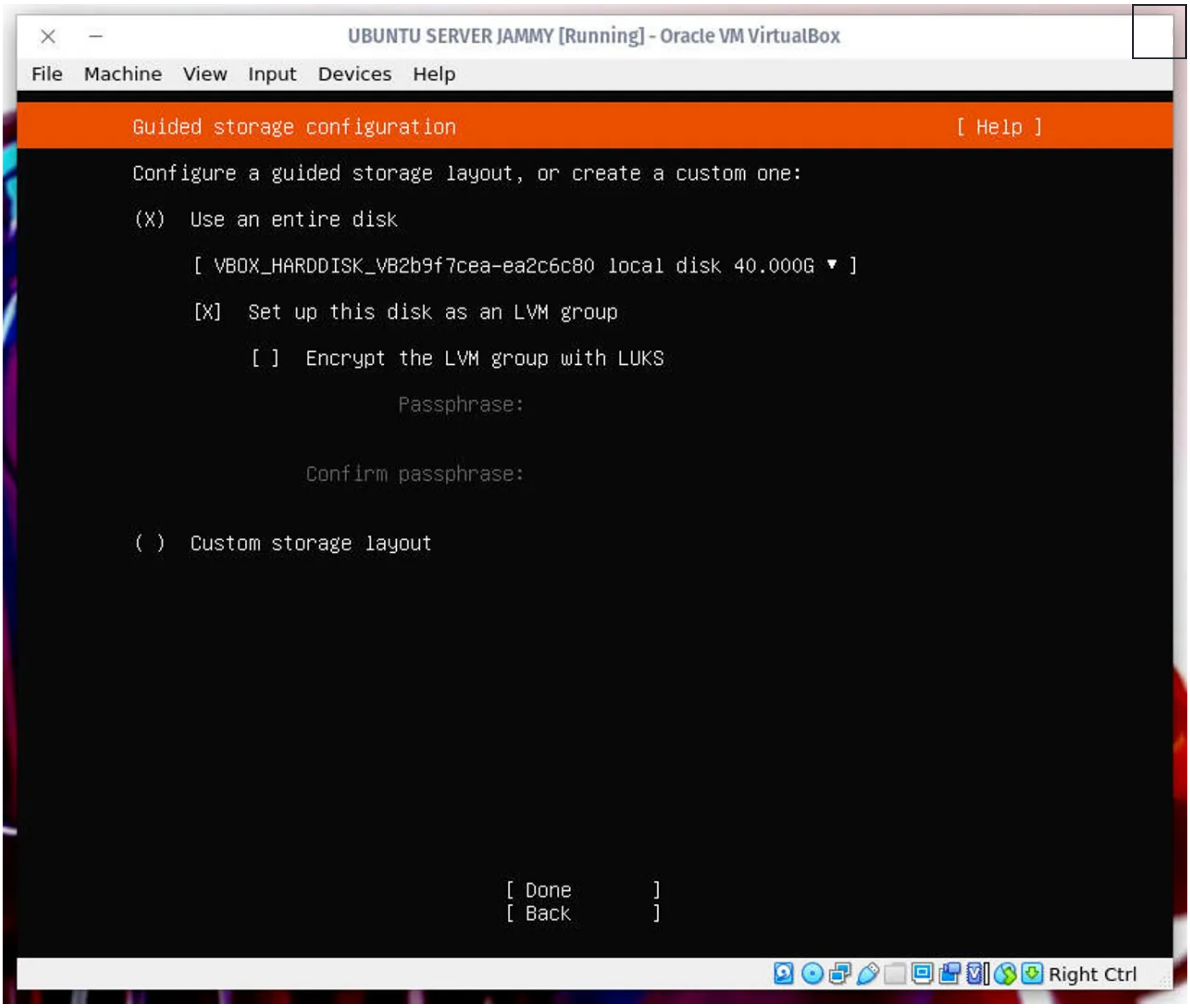
For example, you might enter the following details for the Static IP address:

- Subnet: 192.168.1.0/16
- Address: 192.168.1.33
- Gateway: 192.168.1.1
- Name servers: 1.0.0.1,1.1.1.1

After setting the configuration, tab down to **Done** and hit Enter on your keyboard. You can then skip the proxy configuration, by hitting Enter again. The last step in the network configuration is selecting the mirror address to use. The Mirror address tells your Ubuntu Server instance where to install applications from. Your best bet is to use the default by simply hitting Enter on your keyboard again.

5. Configure storage

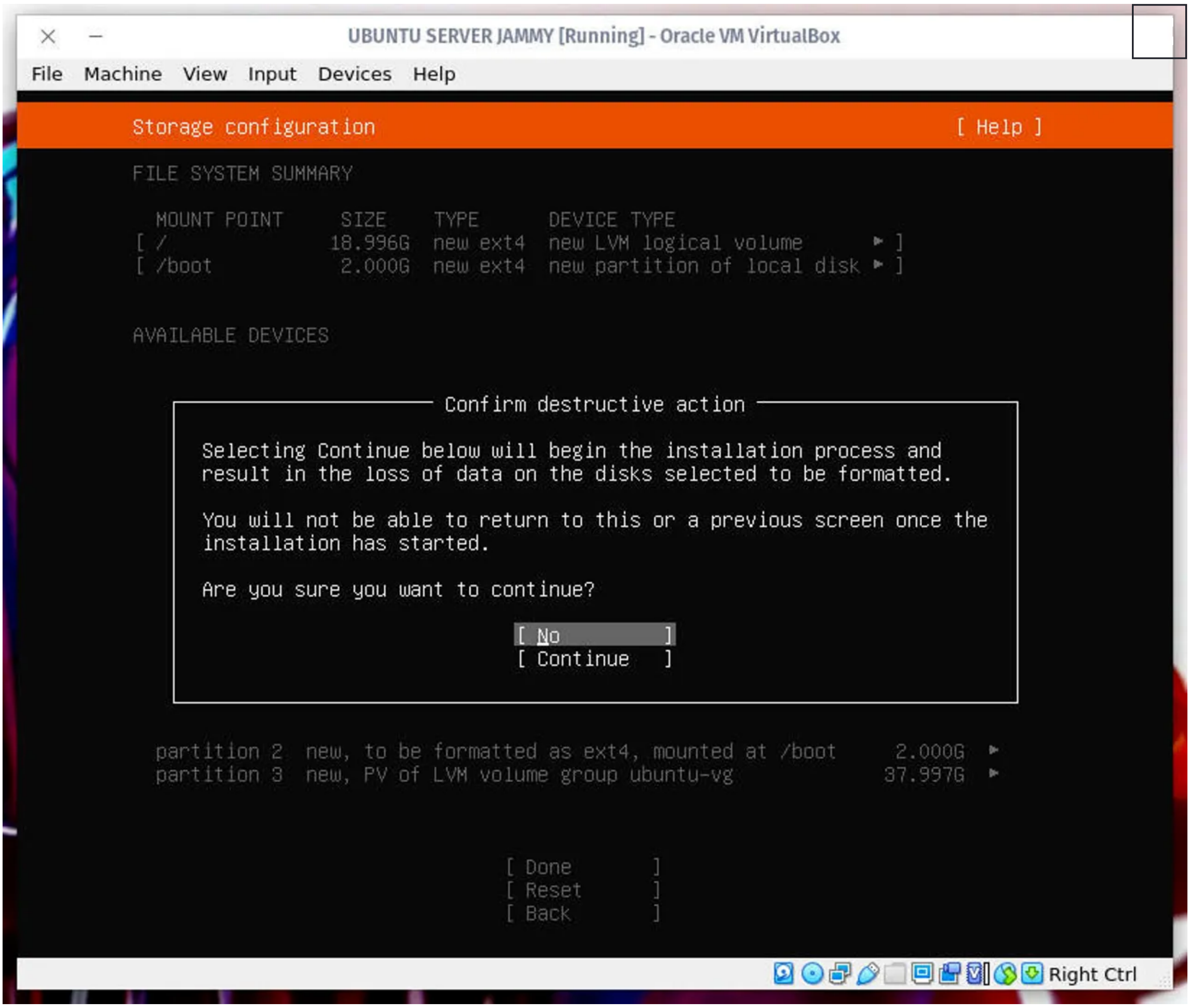
We're going to use our entire disk drive for the installation (which is the default), so leave everything as is, tab down to **Done**, and hit Enter on your keyboard.



Selecting our disk for the installation.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

Review the layout (everything should be good) and hit Enter again to accept the configuration. You'll then be prompted to verify the destructive action, so select **Continue** with your arrow keys and hit Enter on your keyboard.

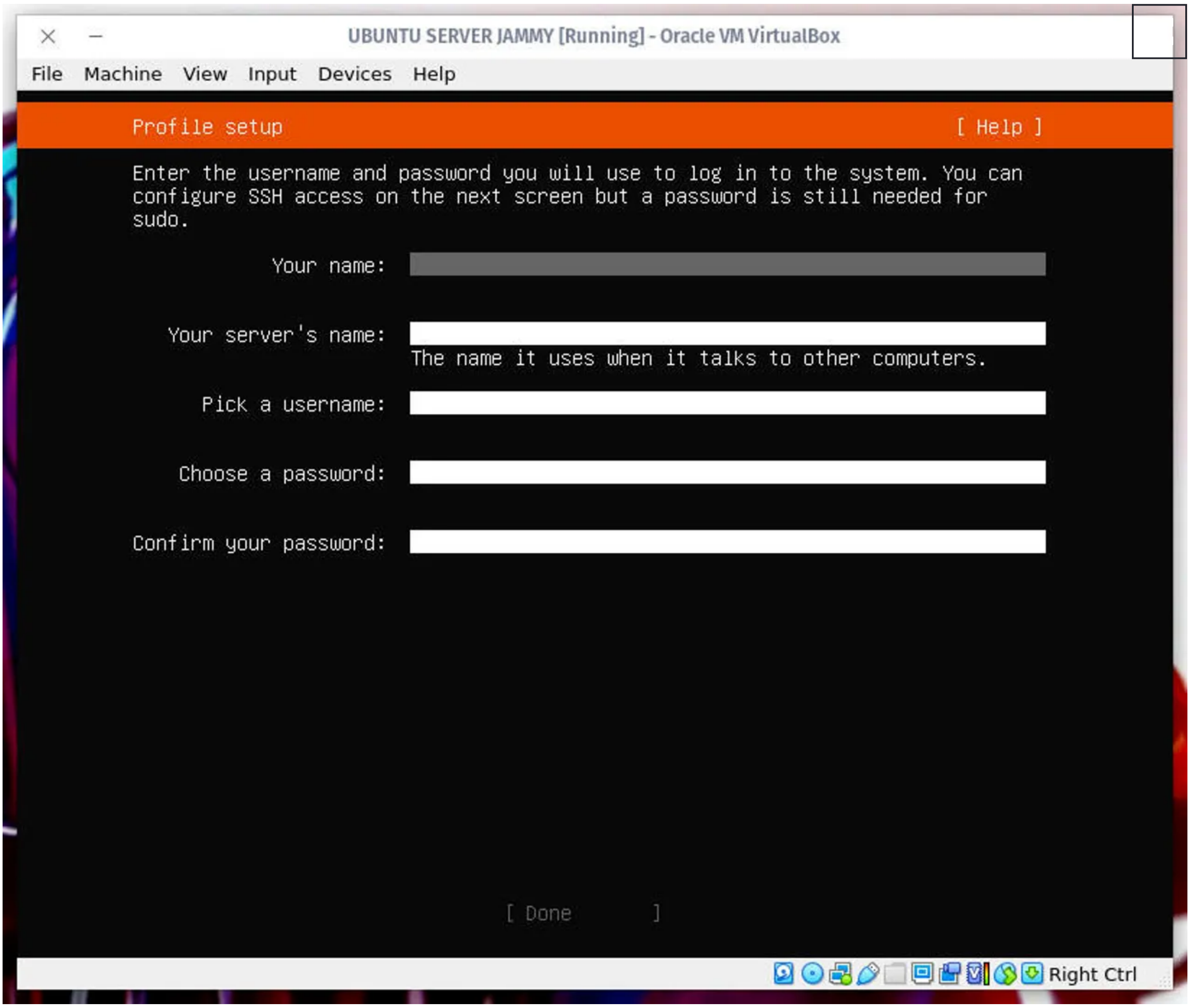


Accepting the destructive action that will begin the installation process.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

6. Create a user

You will now be asked to create a user for the installation. Type out the required details, tab down to **Done**, and hit Enter on your keyboard.

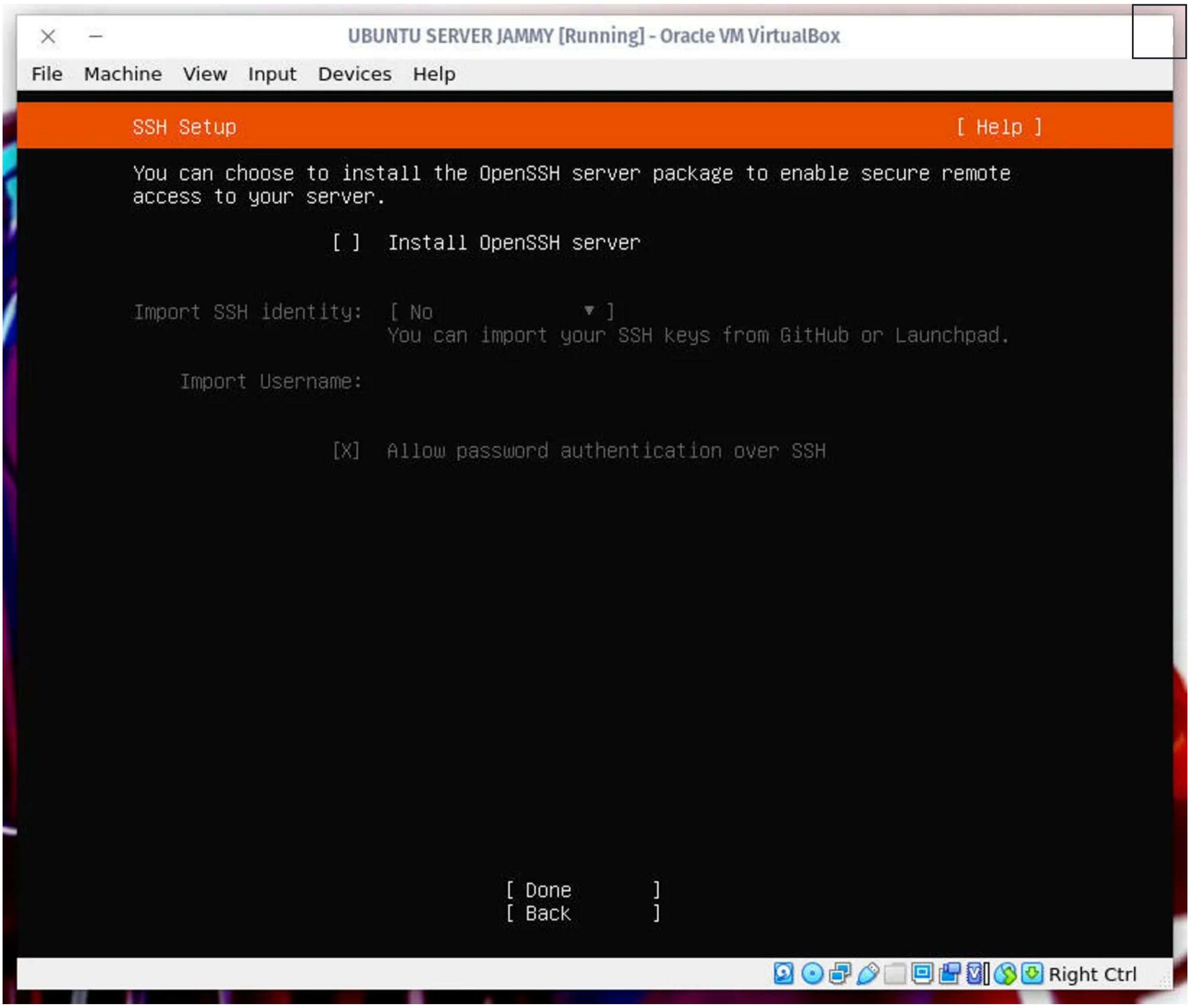


Creating a new user on Ubuntu Server.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

7. SSH Setup and software installation

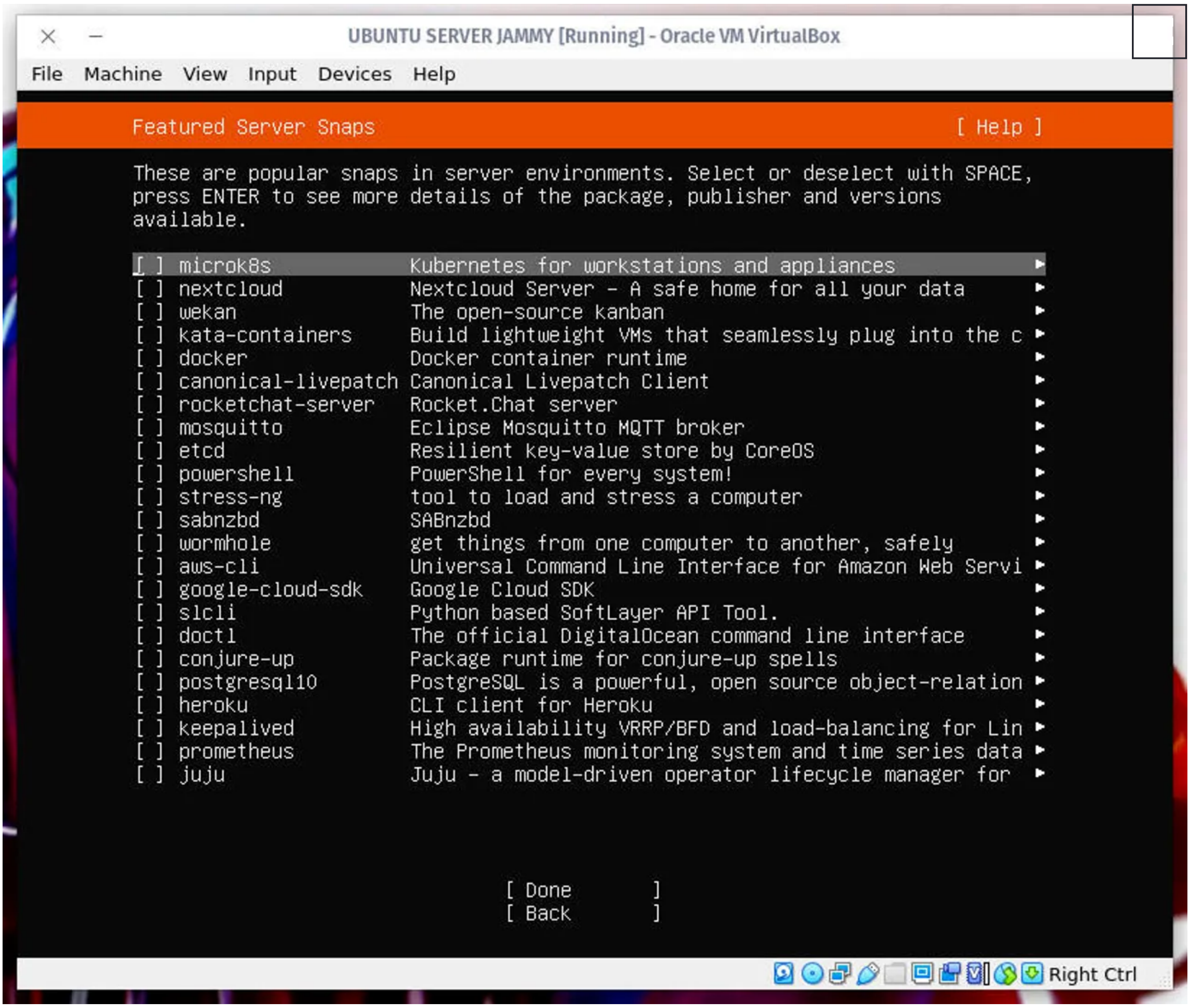
You will, of course, want to enable secure shell access to the server (so you can remotely access it). In the resulting window, enable the installation of the OpenSSH server by hitting the spacebar on your keyboard and then tabbing down to **Done**.



Enabling the installation of OpenSSH.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

In the next screen, scroll through the list of available software to install (selecting the ones you want with the spacebar).



Marking software for installation.

Image: Jack Wallen/ZDNET

After you've made your selections, tab down to **Done** and hit Enter on your keyboard.

At this point, the installation will begin and should take anywhere from 5-10 minutes to complete. Once it finishes, make sure to select Reboot now, remove your USB device, and log in with the user you created during the installation.

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Congratulations, you now have a working instance of Ubuntu Server to use however you see fit. This process shouldn't take you more than 15-30 minutes to complete.

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How to run websites as apps in Linux with any browser

It's easy to run a website as a web app in Linux. We'll show you how.

Written by **Jack Wallen,** Contributing Writer on Aug. 31, 2023

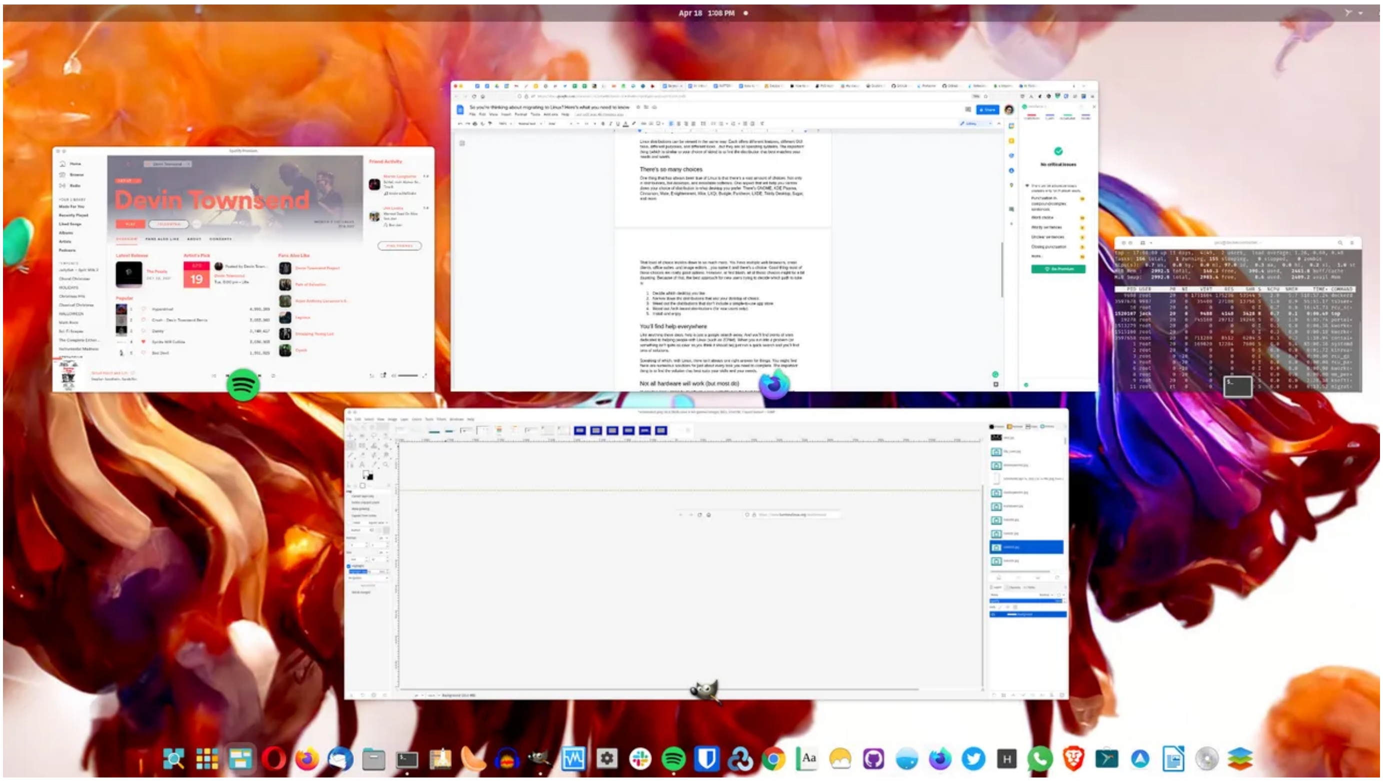

Image: Jack Wallen

There are certain websites I prefer to open as web apps. What does that mean? Simply put, when a site is run as a web app, it will run in its own window (minus all of the web browser accoutrements, such as tabs, menus, and the like) and can be launched directly from your desktop menu.

That might sound familiar to anyone who's used the Chrome browser, as you can create a Shortcut to a site and have it open as its own window (Menu > More Tools > Create shortcut). Other browsers, such as Firefox, don't include such a feature.

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Because of that, you have to turn to a third-party piece of software that is capable of creating a web app out of any site with any browser. In Linux, that app is called Webapp Manager. This application is one of the many installed on Linux Mint, but can also be added to any Ubuntu-based distribution.

Let's get Webapp Manager installed and see how easy it is to create a web app from a site.

How to run websites as apps in Linux

What you'll need: The only thing you'll need for this is a running instance of a Ubuntu-based Linux distribution and a user with sudo privileges. That's it, let's make some desktop magic.

1. Download the DEB file

Open your web browser and point it to the Webapp Manager download page and download the DEB version of the latest release (as of this writing that is 1.2.5).

2. Install Webapp Manager

Open a terminal window and install Webapp Manager with the command:

sudo dpkg ~/Downloads/webapp_manager.deb*

Create your first web app

3. Open the app

Once the application is installed, you can find it listed as Web Apps in your desktop menu. Open it to reveal the very minimal application.

The Webapp Manager UI is very basic and simple.

Screenshot by Jack Wallen

4. Create the app

Click + (the plus sign) and then, in the resulting window, fill out the necessary details for the app. You'll want to give the app a name, which will show in your desktop menu; add the URL for the website; select the browser you want to use from those you've installed on your system; and click OK.

For example, say you want to create an app for Trello. For that you would type Trello for the name, https://www.trello.com for the Address, and Web as the category, then select the browser you want, and click OK. The favicon for the site you use should automatically determine the icon.

Creating a Web App for Trello.

Screenshot by Jack Wallen

5. Open your app

Open your desktop menu and search for the name of the app you just created. For example, if you named the app Trello, it'll be listed as such. When you open the app, you'll find it looks just like a locally installed app (only it's really just a website running in a stripped-down browser window).

The Trello website as seen via a Webapp Manager web app.

Screenshot by Jack Wallen

And that's all there is to running websites as apps in Linux. If you want to separate certain sites from the standard web browser window, this is a great way to do it.

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